

Giving the Benefit of the Doubt

40 min · April Week 3

OBJECTIVE	Students practice charitable interpretation as a daily skill and learn to use the Pause as a concrete, learnable four-step tool.
CASEL FOCUS	Social Awareness: charitable interpretation · Responsible Decision-Making: the Pause as a skill
SCENARIO CARDS	Charitable Cards A (The Ignored Message) & B (The Short Answer)
QUICK REVIEW	1–2 min: "Last lesson: mercy. Quick — what is mercy?" (student answers) "Mercy restrains a response you could make. Today: giving the benefit of the doubt is an even earlier intervention — choosing a generous interpretation BEFORE you respond."

ANCHOR CHART · THE PAUSE — FOUR-STEP ACTION SEQUENCE (ADD TO FLAME VS. PAUSE POSTER)

Add these four steps directly to the existing Flame vs. Pause poster from U3L4. 1. Stop before sending / posting / responding. 2. Ask: What do I actually want to happen here? 3. Consider: What will this action cause? 4. Choose: minimum effective response — or disengage entirely. **New addition:** "Charitable Interpretation" as Step 0 — before the Pause.

OPENING · 2 MINUTES

"When someone you don't know well does something ambiguous, what is your first interpretation? Today we look at where that default comes from — and how to change it."

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · STEPS 1 — 2

I

The Automatic Negative Interpretation

7 MIN

"When someone we don't know well does something ambiguous, our brain's default is often the worst interpretation.

"They ignored me on purpose." "They said that to be mean." Ask: Where does that automatic interpretation come from?"

Take 3–4 responses. **"It comes from in-group/out-group bias — our brains give people in our 'group' the benefit of the doubt automatically. People outside our group do not get that same default. Grace says: extend it anyway."**